

“The only thing keeping ... white GIs alive is us
soul brothers.”

GI CHARLES PORTER, FROM JAMES WESTHEIDER, *FIGHTING IN VIETNAM...*, 2007.

KEY CONCEPT

THE DAP

Black American soldiers in Vietnam often greeted one another with an elaborate handshake called the dap. Customized by unit or hometown, it had political overtones as a display of racial solidarity between Black men, even those who had never met before. The dap could bring activities to a halt, as Black soldiers dapped with every other Black soldier in a club or chow line. Some commanders and white soldiers resented the practice, and Black soldiers risked punishment for engaging in it.

» AFTER

Despite receiving 20 of the 200 Medals of Honor awarded for valor in Vietnam, many Black veterans found that military service did not improve their prospects upon returning home.

VETERANS' STRUGGLE

Many **Black veterans** struggled to find jobs—one commented that a friend who had served time in prison had found work easier to come by than he had. However, some Black Americans **remained in the military** after the war, and many Black officers who served in Vietnam went on to have distinguished military careers.



VETERANS MARION EDMONDS JR. (RIGHT) AND JOSEPH MCLEAN JR. AT THE VIETNAM WOMEN'S MEMORIAL